

money and new foods—there has been a telling change in the health of the country's young citizens. According to a sweeping study conducted by the wellness R&D section of Apollo Hospitals, urban Indian children are not well. For the last one year, Apollo undertook a series of surveys covering 50 schools and 40,000 children, between class VI and XII, across the country—from Hyderabad to Allahabad, Bangalore to Lucknow, Chennai to Mumbai and Pune to Kochi. And by every measure, the report reveals alarming trends: about 34 per cent urban schoolchildren are in poor health.

As many as 62 per cent of the children surveyed eat irregular, untimely meals, snacking and eating junk food through the day. Not so coincidentally, a similar percentage have poor physical stamina and, among other things, become breathless while climbing stairs. A whopping 65 per cent told doctors that they face insoluble daily crises that affect them psychologically (compared to just 15 per cent adults). "Unless some changes are made, this batch of children will grow up with poorer health than the current set of adults in the country," says Professor Adrian Kennedy, who heads the Apollo



Model: KAVYA, Courtesy: GLITZ MODELLING/www.indiatodayimages.com

“ India's couch potato kids do not have the time to play and are turning out to be sitting ducks for bone disorders later in life. ”

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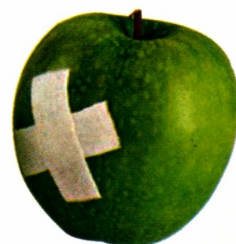


Lifetime Wellness Rx International Ltd.

The survey revealed that more children (34 per cent) are on daily medication than adults (31 per cent). Surprised? Ask the Rajaratnams of Bangalore. The 30-something techie couple makes sure that their seven-year-old son, Rakesh, stays in the best of health, even if that means popping some pills every day. Hence, Rakesh starts his day at the crack of dawn, takes two spoons of specially ordered Chawanprash from Kottakkal in Kerala because “his immune system is weak” and dashes off for his cricket coaching session. “He has to take calcium supplements because he has low bone density,” says his worried mother, Anila. Rakesh also takes a vitamin C supplement in the morning because coughs and colds are a part of his daily life—what with the pollution and the city's weather. Anti-allergics, syrups and paracetamols are not uncommon to Rakesh. Nor are health tonics—for everything from common cold to purifying his blood.

Peruse the stats and children seem to be slipping through the cracks: more children are admitted to hospitals (12 per cent) compared to adults (3 per cent); if 45 per cent adults surveyed

19% feel they are at breaking point, unable to cope with studies



33% of children wear glasses

